SOP-OPS-001 · How a change travels: preview, Promote, main, the public twin

SOP OPS-001 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-01 | For Everyone

Department: OPS · **ID:** 001 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** repository steward · **Last changed:** 2026-11-01

Purpose

So that anyone reading a page knows which copy they are looking at, and so that nothing reaches the public unless someone put its path on a list.

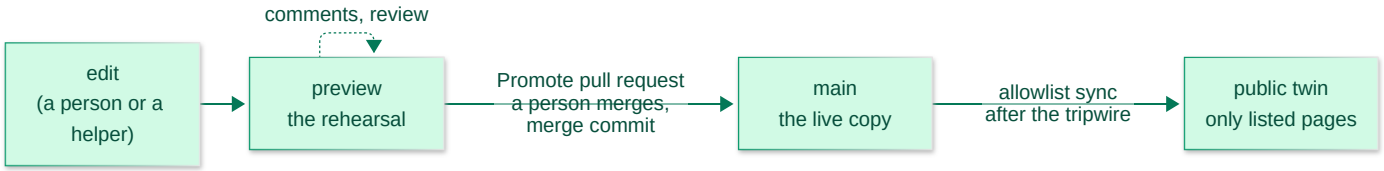
Scope

Every repository in the fleet that has a `preview` branch (sites, drafting desks, Bushido). Organisation `proposals` repositories without a `preview` branch use pull requests into `main` directly; the public-twin rule still applies.

Roles

Role	Does
Author (person or helper)	edits on `preview`, opens the Promote pull request
Reviewer	reads on `preview`, comments
Merger (a human with the role)	merges the Promote; never a helper
Steward	keeps the allowlist and the deploy key

The road



edit · `preview` · Promote · `main` · public twin (SOP-OPS-003 has the twin's rule)

Two things called "preview"

The fleet uses the word *preview* for two different things. They often sit side by side in one repository, which is why they get confused. If you have never used a `preview` branch before, start here.

From zero: what a branch is

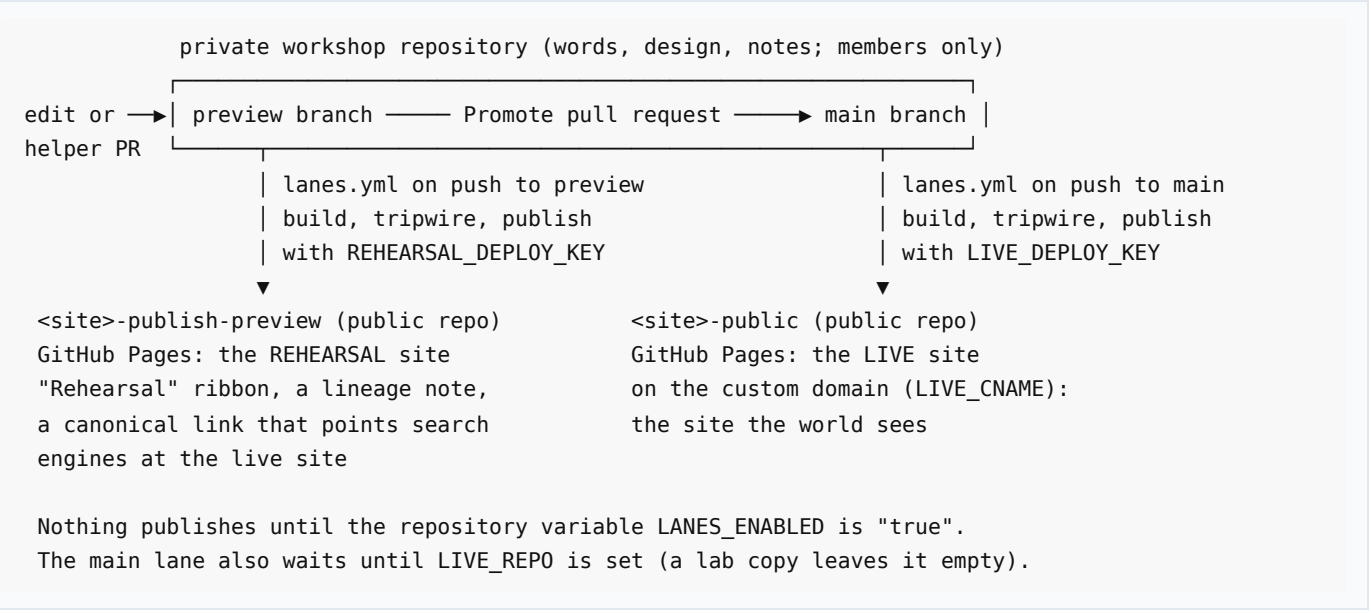
A repository is a folder with its whole history. A **branch** is one named line of that history. Every repository has `main`, the copy everyone treats as real. A repository may also keep a second line called `preview`: the same files, plus whatever changes have not been accepted yet. Switching branches on GitHub (the branch picker above the file list, which says `main` until you change it) shows you the other copy. Nothing is lost by switching; you are only choosing which copy to look at.

Thing one: the `preview` branch (the repository's rehearsal)

- **What it is:** a branch inside one repository where changes land first. Authors and helpers commit there; reviewers read there.
- **How it moves on:** a pull request from `preview` into `main`, titled `Promote: <what>` (SOP-OPS-002). A human with the role merges it with a merge commit; then `main` carries the change.
- **What it publishes:** nothing by itself. It is a holding place for words, code and procedures.
- **Where you find it:** in proposals desks, SOP repositories, Bushido, and every site workshop. On GitHub: the branch picker, or `https://github.com/<owner>/<repo>/tree/preview`.
- **The tell:** a link to `main` shows the old text while your helper says the change is done. It is on `preview`; nobody has merged the Promote yet.

Thing two: the publish-preview *lanes* (a website's rehearsal site)

A **site** repository goes one step further: a workflow (`.github/workflows/lanes.yml`) builds the website from **each** branch and publishes it to a **separate public repository** that serves it with GitHub Pages. Two branches, two websites:



- **Each public repository has its own write deploy key.** The private half lives in the workshop as a secret (`REHEARSAL_DEPLOY_KEY`, `LIVE_DEPLOY_KEY`); the public half is a deploy key on that one public repository. A deploy key opens exactly one repository and never expires, so a key that leaks cannot reach anything else, and publishing cannot stop silently the way an expired personal token does.
- **The tripwire** runs inside the build: research folders, env files or key material in the output fail the build before anything is published.
- **The switch is `LANES_ENABLED`.** Until it is `true`, the workflow file can sit in a repository and do nothing. That is how a lab copy of a site carries the file safely.
- **Every other setting is a repository variable,** not code: `LIVE_REPO` and `REHEARSAL_REPO` (where each lane publishes), `LIVE_SITE_URL`, `LIVE_BASE_PATH`, `LIVE_CNAME`, `REHEARSAL_SITE_URL`, `REHEARSAL_BASE_PATH`, `REHEARSAL_LINEAGE`, and `NEXT_PUBLIC_FORMSPREE_ENDPOINT`. A site's `transition-package/keys-and-locks.md` lists each one, what it does, who holds it and how to replace it, and never a value of a secret.

The admin panel and the form, on a site with lanes

- **The admin panel ("the cockpit")** is part of the site itself: the key icon at the foot of every page, or Ctrl+Shift+X. It shows what is on Live and on Rehearsal, offers ready-made prompts to paste into an AI helper ("on the preview branch, change …, then open a pull request into preview"), an **Edit the words** button that opens the right file on GitHub **on the `preview` branch**, and **Promote rehearsal to live**, which opens a ready-made pull request from `preview` into `main`. Its passcode is a courtesy gate on a static site, not access control: what a person can actually change is decided by their GitHub permissions. The panel manages content (FAQ and page text), not applications.

- **Applications go to Formspree, not to the site.** The form posts to a public Formspree endpoint (the `NEXT_PUBLIC_FORMSPREE_ENDPOINT` variable; public by design, not a secret). Formspree shows each submission in its dashboard, emails it to the team inbox, and can forward it (a spreadsheet, Notion, an automation). The site stores nothing; if Formspree cannot be reached, the form falls back to the visitor's own email. Submissions are read in the Formspree dashboard, not in the admin panel.

Side by side

	`preview` branch	publish-preview lanes
What it is	a second line of history inside one repository	a workflow that builds a website from each branch
Exists in	desks, SOP repositories, Bushido, site workshops	site workshops only
What a reader sees	files on GitHub, branch picker set to `preview`	a real website (the rehearsal site, with a ribbon)
Moves on by	a Promote pull request, merged by a human	the same Promote: merging into `main` rebuilds the live site
Publishes to	nowhere	`<site>-publish-preview` (rehearsal) and `<site>-public` (live)
Credentials	none beyond GitHub membership	one write deploy key per public repository, held as a workshop secret
Switched on by	creating the branch	`LANES_ENABLED = true` (and `LIVE_REPO` set, for the live lane)
Search engines	not applicable	the rehearsal site points them at the live site (canonical link)

Worked example: The Holy Earth Foundation's I Am One Self retreats site. The rehearsal is `theholyearthfoundation/iamoneself-retreats-publish-preview` (served at `theholyearthfoundation.github.io/iamoneself-retreats-publish-preview/`), the live site is `theholyearthfoundation/iamoneself-retreats-public` (served at `retreats.iamoneself.com`), both public; the workshop that feeds them is private to the foundation's members.

Which one am I looking at? A URL on `github.com` with `/tree/preview` or `/blob/preview` is the branch. A website with a "Rehearsal" ribbon is the rehearsal lane. A custom domain without a ribbon is live.

Steps

1. Make the change on `preview`. *You should see:* the commit on the `preview` branch on GitHub; nothing on `main` yet.
2. Open a pull request from `preview` to `main` titled `Promote: <what>` (SOP-OPS-002 says how, and how a helper does it for you). *You should see:* a pull request link.
3. A reviewer reads the pages on `preview` and comments. *You should see:* comments on the pull request, or a plain yes.
4. A human with the role merges with a **merge commit**, never squash (SOP-OPS-002 explains why). *You should see:* `main` carries every commit that was on `preview`, with each author's attribution intact.
5. If the repository has a public twin, the sync copies **only the paths on the allowlist** from `main` to the twin, after a tripwire check. *You should see:* the twin updated minutes later; nothing off the list.

Verification

`git log origin/main..origin/preview` is empty after the merge; the public twin's tree contains exactly the allowlisted paths.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do

The GitHub `main` link shows an old file while the local copy is new	the change is on `preview`; no Promote has been merged	open or merge the Promote (SOP-OPS-002)
A page is on `main` but not on the public twin	its path is not on the allowlist	add the path by pull request, on an officer's yes
The sync fails on the twin	the strict branch ruleset was applied to a twin that the sync force-pushes to	use the deletion-only ruleset for twins (`my-template/branch-protection/`)

Related

- Proposal: THEF 013 *Procedures beside proposals* (why the fleet writes SOPs and how they are approved)
- Proposal: THEF 012 *Your reading room, and how your helper joins you*
- `bushido-code/DEPLOY.md` (the topology this procedure describes), `my-template/branch-protection/README.md`, `my-template/workflow-templates/sync-public-allowlist.yml`
- A site's `.github/workflows/lanes.yml`, `transition-package/keys-and-locks.md` and `how-it-works.md` (the lanes, their keys, the form backend)
- SOP-OPS-002 (the legend of what is protected and what runs on pull requests), SOP-IT-002

Change log

Date	Change	By
2026-10-30	Drafted from the Oct 29 topology and the Oct 30 delivery pass	Alfred
2026-10-31	"Two things called preview": the `preview` branch versus the publish-preview lanes (`lanes.yml`, deploy keys, `LANES_ENABLED`), the admin panel and Formspree, a diagram and a side-by-side table	Alfred
2026-11-01	Lucid pass: Lucide icons on every section, the road drawn in Mermaid (on GitHub and in the PDF), SOP-OPS-003 linked for the twin's rule	Alfred
2026-11-01	ORG's copy brought level with my-template: Lucide icons in emerald, Mermaid where a picture explains, ORG's own facts kept	Alfred

Part of the fleet's procedures. The master copies and the legend live in my-template.